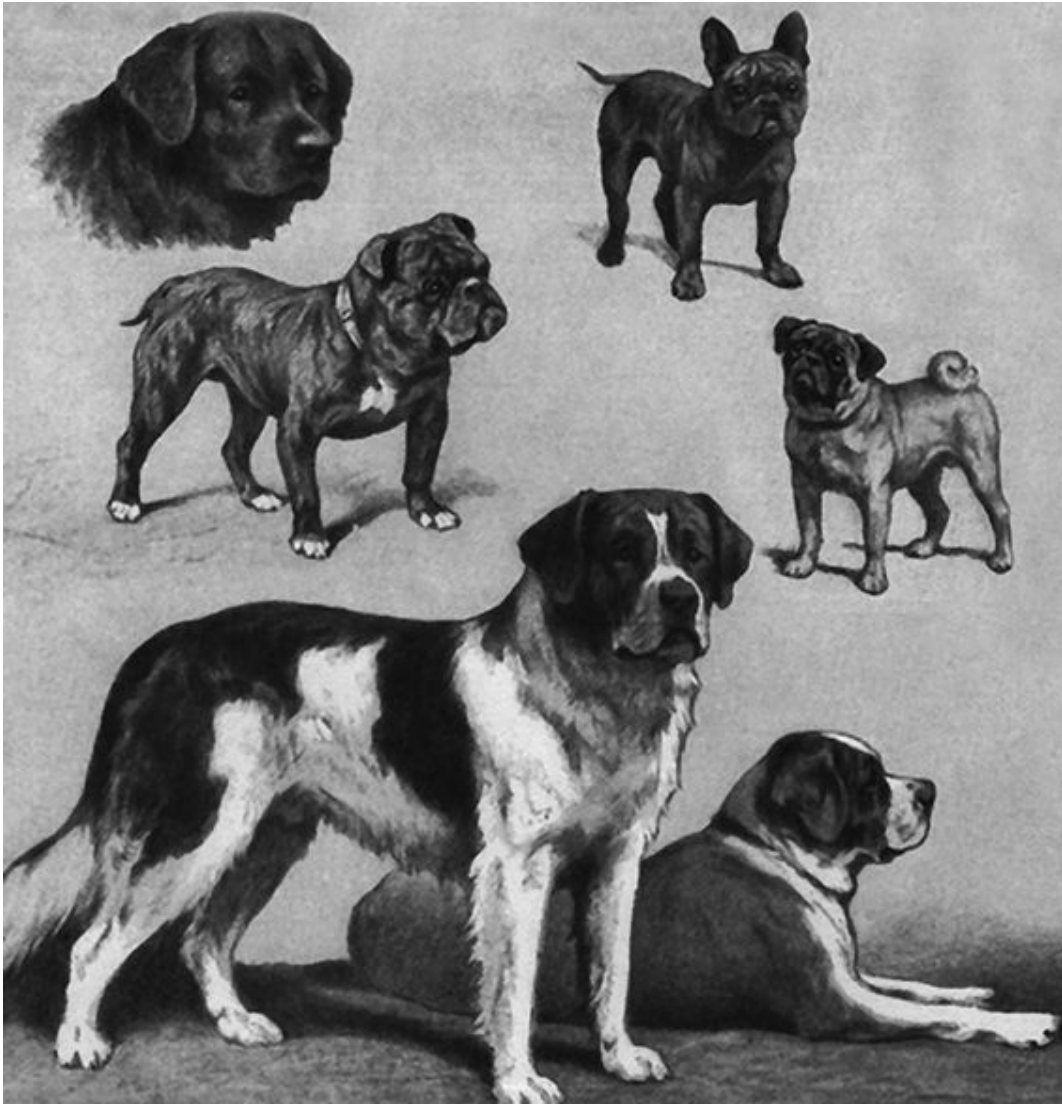


Aristotle: knowledge from experience



From his study of the natural world, Aristotle derived a theory of how we acquire knowledge that was diametrically opposed to that of Plato. He realized that what he knew about plants and animals had come through his observations and concluded that *all knowledge* came from experience.

For example, when he saw a dog, he could recognize it as a dog, even though dogs come in all shapes and sizes. Plato explained this as coming from an innate knowledge of a world of Forms (see [Plato's theory of Forms](#)). But Aristotle reasoned that it was because he had seen a number of

dogs before and gradually built an idea of what constitutes a dog from their common characteristics – from the various separate instances of ‘dog’, he had derived a concept of ‘dogginess’. In a similar way, we understand abstract concepts such as justice or virtue from our experience of various instances of them. Knowledge of anything is therefore empirical – it is only after experience of something via our senses that we can apply the process of rational thought.